

HANDOUT 3: Conversation Planning Guide

A step-by-step guide for preparing to speak with families.

BEFORE THE CONVERSATION

Gather your documentation: Review your observation notes. Select 2–4 specific, dated examples.

List the child's strengths: Identify at least 3 genuine strengths you will share first.

Clarify your purpose: Are you sharing information? Seeking family input? Suggesting a referral? Know your goal.

Choose the right setting: Request a private meeting — not drop-off or pick-up. Allow adequate time.

Consider the family: Reflect on language, culture, family circumstances, and any prior history.

Arrange interpretation: If needed, arrange for a qualified interpreter. Do not use children as interpreters.

WHAT TO BRING

Observation documentation: Copies of your dated, objective observation notes.

Strengths list: Your written list of what the child does well.

Resource list: Referrals or supports you may recommend.

Conversation Planning Worksheet: Your completed planning worksheet.

Pen and notepad: For taking notes during the conversation.

HOW TO OPEN THE CONVERSATION

Start with appreciation: "Thank you for taking the time to meet with me today."

State your purpose warmly: "I wanted to share some observations and hear what you are noticing at home."

Lead with strengths: "I always love having [child's name] in our group. Here are some things I really appreciate about [him/her/them]..."

HOW TO SHARE CONCERNS RESPECTFULLY

Use objective language: Share your documented observations — not labels or judgments.

Focus on patterns: "Over the past few weeks, we have noticed..."

Avoid diagnosis language: You are sharing what you see, not what it means medically.

Use 'I' statements: "I have noticed..." rather than "Your child is..."

HOW TO INVITE FAMILY INPUT

Ask open-ended questions: "What do you see at home?" and "What works well for your child?"

Listen without interrupting: Give families time to respond. Silence is okay.

Validate their experience: "That makes sense." "Thank you for sharing that with me."

HOW TO RESPOND TO EMOTIONS

Worry or fear: "It makes sense that this feels worrying. Let's take this one step at a time."

Denial: "I understand this may be surprising. I'd love to keep the conversation open."

Anger: Stay calm. "I hear you. I want to work with you, not against you."

Sadness: Give space. "Please take all the time you need. I'm here with you."

HOW TO DISCUSS NEXT STEPS

Be specific: "Here is what I will do in the program..."

Invite collaboration: "What would you like to try at home?"

Mention referrals gently: "There is a program called Early Intervention that offers free evaluations for children under 3. Would you like more information?"

Make a plan: "Let's plan to check in again on [date]."

HOW TO CLOSE THE CONVERSATION

Summarize agreements: Briefly repeat what was discussed and agreed upon.

Express partnership: "I am really glad we had this conversation. I'm committed to supporting your child."

Confirm follow-up: "I'll send home a note with the information we discussed. Let's connect again on [date]."

Thank the family: "Thank you for your time and for trusting me with your child."